

S

SOMETIMES, GETTING into something may be easier than getting out of it. Just ask the HR professionals witnessing up close employees' return to office under hybrid work as companies roll back pandemic-led

work-from-home benefits. If moving tens of thousands of employees into remote work overnight at the pandemic's outset was a challenge, bringing them back to office under a hybrid model suitable to both employers and employees at a time of record-high attrition levels is proving to be a bigger one.

"Today, the heated job market is not helping the cause of bringing people back to office. The ability of organisations to take hard calls is not there," says talent solutions provider Careernet's CEO & Co-founder Anshuman Das, adding that companies are definitely facing resistance from at least a few employees when told to return to office. Agreeing, another senior HR professional who requested anonymity, says: "Employees are saying, 'You don't decide my life, I decide it'. Many of them who have moved back to smaller towns are asking if they need this particular job to cover their expenses."

With vaccination gathering pace, the Omicron wave proving to be mild and India Inc. becoming more confident of managing the virus better, employers' collective chants have also changed from 'the future of work is remote' to 'the future of work is hybrid' to 'one size does not fit all'. Yet to crack a hybrid model that works for them, several companies have been gearing up for more in-office work under a hybrid mode, with specifics varying across industries, management styles and roles.

Employees are back mostly in banking, financial services and even in IT and start-ups, which were expected

to lead the hybrid-work pack given their digital quotient, Das says. "The return of employees to physical offices and workplaces is yet to gain the sense of normalcy that was once present. We are still witnessing low occupancy rates. But as things are picking up pace, we are seeing several organisations resume their 'work from office' practice," says Sreelakshmi Venugopal, Head of HR at Embassy Services, which runs facility management services for large business parks in the country.

Sunjoy Dhaawan, VP of Human Resources at DHL Express (India) agrees that the company's management has debated the topic several times. "People can turn back to us and say, 'Look, in the last two years I've worked very efficiently sitting at home and my work hasn't suffered. So why do I need to come to office?'" Their justification is that the office space becomes necessary for newcomers at least to get a sense of the company culture. But he adds that they haven't had any requests for fully remote work, possibly because they allow employees 10 days of work from home in a month.

Other leading employers also say they haven't received many employee requests to continue working from home. "Our experience has been that a majority of employees are able to manage these situations as long as they have the flexibility to manage their work. They actually look forward to being in office two to three days a week," says Tata Consumer Products (TCP) Global CHRO Amit Chincholikar. "We are encouraging all our colleagues to join us in the office/work the market for at least three days a week and have received good response," says an HUL spokesperson, adding that people with exceptional circumstances can discuss work options with their line managers. Adds S.V. Nathan, Partner and Chief Talent Officer, Deloitte India: "Our experiences and response will evolve as we have just started hybrid working in March."

To be sure, many employees are glad to be back in office. At least there's a clear end to the day, reason some. Others are not ready to suffer the boredom and digital exhaustion of working from home anymore. But there

are also many who don't want to return. Consider this: Naukri.com added a feature in July 2021 for recruiters to tag their job postings as 'Permanent Remote' or 'Temporary Work from Home During Covid'. According to the job portal's findings released in February 2021, over 93,000 permanent and temporary remote jobs were listed. Indian job seekers made over 3.2 million searches for permanent and temporary remote jobs. About 57

EMPLOYEES MAY NOT HAVE MUCH CHOICE IF COMPANIES REQUIRE THEM TO RETURN TO OFFICE AS LONG AS THE STATE AND CENTRAL GOVERNMENTS' RULES DON'T PROHIBIT THEM